

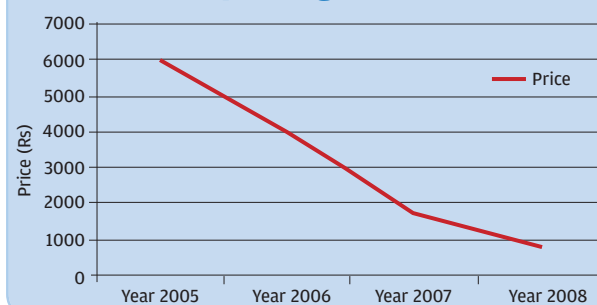
Storage



Hard drives and storage have come a very long way. Storage drives keep getting cheaper and then capacities keep on increasing. The demand for higher capacity drives has also kept up, thanks to the whole broadband revolution that's spreading across India. Prices have dropped so low that a good 500 GB hard drive can be easily purchased for under Rs 4,000. It's no longer just all about capacity anymore. There are many other factors that should govern a buying decisions and these are some of the most important ones.



Flash drive pricing



Design

Flash drives are objects that you forget about, after use. They are used everyday and go through a beating. So it's important that it be sturdy. Look for drives that come with a rubber body, so they don't break or get damaged if thrown around. Such drives also happen to be water resistant. Flash drives with caps or sliding mechanisms can also stop the USB connector from getting damaged. Make sure your drive has a status indicator that shows whether the drive is in use.



Rugged flash drive

Flash-drive-foldable

Flash-drive-cap

Flash Drive Security

Some flash drives come with built-in security features. This allows the user to set a password to a partition on the drive. This way, only authorised users can access data on it. Look for drives that can encrypt data as well.



Performance

Performance helps when you want to quickly copy some data before leaving for work. If you plan on using the drive for Vista for ReadyBoost or run a portable Linux distribution, performance helps. Anything over 25 and 30 MB/s can be considered as a good standard for performance drives. Entry-level value drives will perform around half that.

Hard Drive Cache

The cache on a hard drive is some indication of the performance of the drive. Look for drives that come with 32 MB cache. These large buffers are only present on some of the newest hard drives from manufacturers.



SATA 2

SATA 2 is an absolute must for fast drives. SATA 2 has no changes to the hardware, but the standard allows speeds of upto 3 Gbps. Also, make sure your motherboard supports SATA 2. Being backward-compliant, older standards still work.

Heat

Faster the hard drives get, the hotter they get. Try and look for drives that have a compact design, but have a big bulky cooler to control temperatures. Some of the drives have high density platters, so only a single platter or two is sufficient. These drives are generally thinner and also run considerably cooler.



Warranty

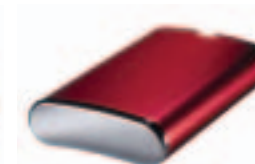
With the speeds at which the drives run these days, operating temperatures are high. Reliability has been an issue, especially with continuous operations. Many manufacturers give a very long warranty period — something like five years. Some of the warranty schemes are highly attractive. The company sends over somebody to pick up the drive and send it over within a week.

External hard drives build quality

The most important factor in external hard drives is the case. The case should be rigid and be able to withstand daily rough use. It shouldn't be too bulky that it always requires a bag to be carried around. Some manufacturers have incorporated sturdiness and great catchy designs to suit the style-conscious.



Rugged hard drive



Stylish External hard drive

Interface

Portable hard drives typically come with all kinds of interfaces — the most common being USB. Make sure the drive is a USB 2.0 compliant drive. There are some drives that can be E-SATA and some with Firewire. E-SATA is bound to be a tiny bit costlier but do not spend in excess for these drives.



eSATA



USB



Firewire

Networking

Networking functions have become part of some external drives. These drives come with some built-in firmware to let users dump data on the drives over the network. If you do want a network drive, then also look at what kind of software comes built into it. Look for FTP hosting features on the drive.

